

ANI

Modi can expect friction with his allies over special category status and the caste census. Naidu is also committed to 4% quota for Muslims in Andhra

The central government is also opposed to granting special category status, especially after the 14th Finance Commission advised against it. These and other issues have the potential to create an impasse and lead to a breakdown in ties.

MANUFACTURING A MAJORITY

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh ideologue Seshadri Chari expresses complete faith in Modi being able to handle both allies and run-ins with other parties with skill. As he says, "He and the allies have complementary requirements that will help them stay together. There is a win-win situation in the relationship. Or put another way, it's like two nuclear weapon powers who know there is a mutually assured destruction if either party falters." Chari, who has also worked closely with Vajpayee, believes that like the late prime minister, Modi too has always been first among equals, which bestows on him the authority to ward off any challenge he may encounter within the party and outside of it. Another political insider, who doesn't wish to be named, says Modi will be even more determined to succeed. "Those who think Modi's wings have been clipped are mistaken," he says. "He will not only ensure that he flies far above others but will also go after his opponents mercilessly." The prime minister made clear that intent emphatically in his victory address, saying that he would continue to come down heavily on corruption, sending a clear warning to his political opponents.

Among the things Modi and the BJP will do in the coming months is to try to shore up their majority to become less dependent on the current set of allies. This may mean getting MPs from other parties to resign and contest afresh. But Tiwari reckons that the BJP's winnability index has diminished considerably after this election and many may be wary of going down the resignation route. The other option is to have other parties, especially the smaller ones, merge with the BJP, or engineer splits among them, like with the Shiv Sena and NCP, and onboard them as allies. The danger there is that it could deepen the negative perception about the BJP, the current results in Maharashtra being a case in point. Other contradictions abound. Modi has been a vociferous opponent of *parivarvaad* or dynastic politics, but Naidu epitomises it in Andhra, being the son-in-law of TDP founder, the late N.T. Ramarao, with a clutch of close relatives in the party. The BJP also needs to cleanse the accusation of being a "washing machine" for leaders in other parties who have cases against them that mysteriously disappear once they switch sides, as happened in Maharashtra. Corruption hardly figured in Modi's campaign speeches in the state. The greater test will be the assembly election in the state later this year; if the BJP and its allies lose, experts believe it will spell the beginning of the end of the NDA coalition. Modi will have to work hard to ensure that 3.0 does not become Three Point Zero.

THE AGENDA FOR MODI 3.0

The real test for Modi now lies in handling the economy and addressing the key burning issues of unemployment and inequitable economic growth. The PM has several advantages that give him the confidence to achieve his goals. He had also, in the last months of his second term, got his ministries to work both on short- and long-term plans for transformation. B.V.R. Subrahmanyam, the CEO of government think-tank NITI Aayog, believes that India remains in a demographic sweet spot with its population at a median age of 29 years compared to 39 for countries like China and the US. That makes India and Africa the only regions to have youthful working populations. It is imperative for them, therefore, that their economies grow rapidly. As Subrahmanyam warns,